

The Noble Sūtra of Ānanda of the Mountain

Giri Ānanda Sūtra · Toh 38 · Derge Kangyur

རི་ཀུན་དགའ་བའི་མཛད།

The Noble Sūtra of Ānanda of the Mountain, known in Sanskrit as the Giri Ānanda Sūtra and in Tibetan as Ri'i Kun dga' bo'i mdo, is a short sūtra belonging to the class of noble discourses attributed to the Buddha himself. It recounts an episode in which the venerable Ānanda falls gravely ill and approaches the Blessed One at Śrāvastī, prompting the Buddha to offer teachings connected with contemplation and the relief of suffering. The text is Toh 38 in the Kangyur, the collection of canonical scriptures regarded as the word of the Buddha, and sits within the sūtra section of that canon. It was translated into Tibetan at the great temple of Dpal Thar pa Gling, where it was edited and finalized for transmission to Tibetan readers.

the great temple of Dpal Thar pa Gling, where it was translated, edited, and finalized. May it be like the sun and the moon above the earth.

The Noble Sūtra of Ānanda of the Mountain.

In the language of India: Giri Ānanda Sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Sūtra of the Mountain's Ānanda.

I prostrate with reverence to the noble Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada. At that time, the venerable Ānanda of the Mountain was afflicted by a serious illness and tormented by suffering. Then the venerable Ānanda went to where the Blessed One was, approached him, prostrated to the Blessed One, and sat down to one side. Having sat to one side, the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable one, the venerable monk Ānanda of the Mountain is afflicted by a serious illness and tormented by suffering. Venerable Blessed One, please act well. I beseech you to go with compassionate care to where the monk, the venerable Ānanda of the Mountain, is dwelling."

Then the Blessed One spoke to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, go to the monk Ānanda of the Mountain and teach him the ten perceptions. Speak to him in a way that is accompanied by clear understanding. Furthermore, when the monk Ānanda of the Mountain hears these ten perceptions, he will come to understand distinctly each of those conditions that are tormented by illness.

What are the ten? The perception of impermanence, the perception of no-self, the perception of impurity, the perception of what is to be cut off, the perception of abandonment, the perception of freedom from attachment, the perception of cessation, the perception of non-delight in the entire world, the perception of impermanence with regard to all formations, and the perception that accompanies mindfulness of inhalation and exhalation. What is the perception of impermanence? This, venerable Ānanda, is to be understood distinctly: go to a forest hermitage, or the foot of a tree, or an empty dwelling, and reflect thus. Form is impermanent, feeling is impermanent, perception is impermanent, formations are impermanent, consciousness is impermanent — in this way, regard these five aggregates of clinging as impermanent. Teach that perception of impermanence. Ānanda, what is the perception of no-self? This, monk Ānanda, is to be understood distinctly: go to a forest hermitage, or the foot of a tree, or an empty dwelling, and reflect thus. The eye is without self, forms are without self, the ear is without self, sounds are without self, the nose is without self, smells are without self, the tongue is without self, tastes are without self, the body is without self, tangible objects are without self, the mind is without self, mental phenomena are without self — these six inner sense bases and six outer sense bases are without self. One should look upon and contemplate no-self. Ānanda, teach these instances of no-self. Ānanda, what is the perception of impurity? Monk Ānanda, in regard to this very body, from the top of the crown down to the soles of the feet, within the outer covering of skin — one should examine individually the manifold impurities with which it is filled. In this body there are: hair of the head, body hair, nails, teeth, outer skin, flesh, sinew, bone, marrow, kidneys, heart, liver, lungs, stomach contents, stomach, intestines, intestinal membrane, bladder, feces, bile, phlegm, joints, blood, sweat, fat, tears, lymph, saliva, mucus, serum, urine, and brain — thirty-two substances that are impure. One should regard this body as impure."

"Ānanda, teach these impurities.

Now, Ānanda, what are the interruptions? Monk Ānanda, one should go to a forest, to the foot of a tree, or to an empty dwelling, and examine each of these individually. This body is full of suffering and full of interruptions; from this body many kinds of illness arise. They are as follows: disease of the eye, disease of the ear, disease of the nose, disease of the tongue, disease of the body, disease of the head, disease within the ear, disease of the mouth, disease of the teeth, disease of the lungs, discomfort of breath, disease of the

sinuses, fever, disease of the stomach, fainting, pain in the side, stabbing pain, cramping, leprosy, tumors, fine eruptions, wasting disease, the disease of forgetfulness, scabs, itching, erosion of the body, rashes, the disease of vīcarcikā, blood and bile disorders, the disease of madhumeha, the disease of aṅga, the disease of silākā, nocturnal emission, disease of disturbed bile, disease of disturbed phlegm, disease of disturbed wind, combined disorders, the disease of food not reaching the stomach in due time, disorders of imbalance arising together, the disease of aupakāsmṛkā, disease arising from the ripening of karma, cold, heat, hunger and thirst, diarrhea, and dropsy. All these diseases of the body should be regarded and contemplated as interruptions. Ānanda, this is what is to be taught as the interruptions.

Now, Ānanda, what are the perceptions of abandonment? Monk Ānanda, that which has arisen from desire should be relinquished without remainder — to be analyzed, not to be cultivated, not to be meditated upon, and that which has arisen from harmful thoughts should be relinquished without remainder — to be analyzed, not to be cultivated, not to be meditated upon. Evil, unwholesome phenomena that have arisen and continue to arise should be relinquished without remainder — to be analyzed, not to be cultivated, not to be meditated upon. Ānanda, these are called the perceptions of abandonment.

Now, Ānanda, what is the perception of freedom from attachment and desire? Monk Ānanda, one should go to a forest, to the foot of a tree, or to an empty dwelling, and examine individually: 'This is the peaceful, the excellent — that which is the subsiding of all conditioned things, the cessation of birth, the transformation away from craving, cessation, nirvāṇa.' Ānanda, this is called the perception of cessation.

Now, Ānanda, what is the perception of non-delight in the entire world? Monk Ānanda, one abandons whatever arises in the world in relation to means and conditions, whatever is conceptualized, whatever abides, whatever lies dormant as habitual tendency, and one does not generate delight in it. Ānanda, this is what is to be taught as the perception of non-delight in the entire world.

Now, Ānanda, what is the perception of impermanence in all formations? Monk Ānanda, with regard to all formations one has no clinging, one abandons them, and one is repelled by them. Ānanda, this is what is to be taught as the perception of impermanence in all formations.

Now, Ānanda, what is mindfulness of the in-breath and out-breath? Monk Ānanda, one should go to a forest, to the foot of a tree, or to an empty dwelling, sit down, take the cross-legged posture, hold the body upright, and with the gaze directed slightly upward, remain established in mindfulness. Then, when one breathes out a short breath, one clearly knows: 'I have breathed out a short breath.' When one breathes in long or short, one clearly knows: 'I am breathing in.' When one breathes out long, one clearly knows: 'I have breathed out long.' When one breathes out short or briefly, one clearly knows: 'I have breathed out a short breath.'"

When one breathes out a short breath, one clearly knows: "I have breathed out a short breath." One trains thus: "Fully experiencing the entire body, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to look upon and fully experience the body. One trains to look upon and fully experience the body. Having thoroughly calmed the bodily formations, one clearly knows when breathing in a short breath: "I am breathing in," and trains to look upon that inhalation. Seeing both, one breathes out a short breath, having thoroughly calmed the bodily formations; and one trains to remain thus. Seeing both, one trains to remain looking upon the bodily formations.

One trains thus: "Fully experiencing joy, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to look upon and fully experience joy. One trains thus: "Fully experiencing happiness, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to look upon and fully experience happiness. One trains thus: "Fully experiencing the mental formations, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to look upon and fully experience the mental formations. Seeing both, one trains thus: "Fully experiencing the mental formations, I shall breathe out a short breath." Seeing both, one trains thus: "I have thoroughly calmed the mental formations."

When one fully experiences the mind and breathes in a short breath, one trains: "I am breathing in." One trains to fully experience the mind and thoroughly settle it. One trains thus: "With the mind aroused to clear delight, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains thus: "I have thoroughly settled the mind aroused to clear delight." One trains thus: "With the mind abiding in calm abiding, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to abide in insight while the mind rests in calm abiding. One trains thus: "With the mind fully liberated, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to abide in insight with the mind fully liberated.

One trains thus: "Contemplating impermanence as I follow along, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to abide in insight while contemplating impermanence. One trains thus: "Contemplating dispassion as I follow along, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to abide in insight while contemplating dispassion. One trains thus: "Contemplating cessation as I follow along, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to abide in insight while contemplating cessation. One trains thus: "Contemplating relinquishment as I follow along, I shall breathe out a short breath." One trains to abide in insight while contemplating relinquishment.

Ānanda, this is the teaching on mindfulness of in-breath and out-breath. Therefore, Ānanda, go to the dwelling of the Elder Ānanda on the mountain, and explain these ten perceptions to him. There is something further: if the monk Elder Ānanda hears these ten perceptions, all his illness shall be pacified.

Thereupon the venerable Ānanda listened to the Blessed One and went to the dwelling of the Elder Ānanda on the mountain, and explained these ten perceptions to the venerable Elder Ānanda one by one. When the venerable Elder Ānanda had heard these ten perceptions, all his illness was pacified. When all his illness had been pacified, the venerable Elder Ānanda rose from his bed, and thereafter the venerable Elder Ānanda's illness was no more.

This concludes the Sūtra of the Venerable Elder Ānanda.

Translated from the teachings of the great paṇḍita Ānandaśrī by the learned translator, the Śākya monk Nyi ma rgyal mtshan dpal bzang po.

Colophon in two languages.

Translator's Notes

- The opening lines form the colophon of a preceding text and the title incipit of the Giriānanda Sūtra appearing together. The Giriānanda Sūtra (Pali: Girimānanda Sutta, AN 10.60) is a canonical discourse on ten perceptions (saṃjñā) taught to heal a sick monk. The Tibetan title renders the monk's name as "Ri'i Kun dga' bo" — literally "Ānanda of the Mountain" — translating the Sanskrit Giri (mountain) rather than treating the name as a pure proper noun. This translation preserves that rendering throughout for accuracy.

The term rendered "stomach contents" (Tibetan sul mang) is uncertain; it may refer to the contents of the intestines or to a specific anatomical substance. It is a standard member of the classical Abhidharma body-parts list and is placed here accordingly.

- The list of diseases contains several terms transliterated from Sanskrit or Middle Indic that resist certain identification in their Tibetan phonetic rendering. "Madhumeha" is the classical Sanskrit term for diabetes mellitus or a sweet-urine disorder. "Vīcarcikā" denotes a skin

disease, often identified as eczema or scabies in Āyurvedic sources. "Aupakāśmṛkā" is uncertain; it may be a corrupt or dialectal form of a Sanskrit disease name, and the rendering here is a transliteration pending better identification. "Silākā" and "aṅga" likewise appear to be phonetic transcriptions of Indic medical terms whose precise identification is uncertain.

The instruction about the direction of the gaze — rendered "with the gaze directed slightly upward" — translates a phrase that could also mean "with the face raised upward" or simply "looking forward"; the traditional posture instruction in parallel sūtra sources more commonly specifies straightening of the body without specifying an upward gaze, so this detail may reflect a variant textual tradition or a specific meditative instruction within this text.

- The passage involves two figures both named Ānanda: the well-known attendant of the Buddha (who receives the teaching and then conveys it), and a second figure, the "Elder Ānanda" who is sick and dwelling on a mountain. The Tibetan distinguishes these by context, and the rendering attempts to preserve this distinction throughout. The phrase "rī'i Kun dga' bo" likely means the Elder Ānanda residing on the mountain, and is rendered accordingly.

The ten perceptions referred to correspond to the sixteen stages of mindfulness of breathing that have been taught in the passage, though the Tibetan calls them "ten perceptions." This may reflect a different recension or a summarizing enumeration; no emendation has been made to the translation.

- This is a colophon notation indicating that the text exists in a bilingual edition, literally "two languages," referring to the Sanskrit and Tibetan versions of the text.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.